EAST BAY PERMACULTURE GUILD · HACK FOR SOCIAL IMPACT 2026

Roots

Volunteers who come back.

Reasons that make every hour count, AI that knows your people, and money that funds more volunteer days.

Built on Garden Steward · Demo uses fictional volunteers

THE GUILD’S CHALLENGE

“Build simple tools to help the Guild welcome new members, understand how they want to participate, and turn event details into outreach ready for volunteer review.”

“Keep it affordable, easy for volunteers to maintain, and true to the personal connections.”

East Bay Permaculture Guild · written challenge for Hack for Social Impact 2026

People come once. Then life gets in the way.

8 of 35

people in our demo community came once and have not been back.

A garden needs the same hands every month.

Monthly work days, a free pantry and two big unconferences a year all run on volunteers who return.

Demo figures use fictional volunteers. The Guild’s activities are from its hack brief.

Roots gives people three reasons to stay.

1 · FIRST

Hours that count

School hours, FFA, college credit, CalFresh. A benefit for the person, not just the garden.

2 · THEN

A personal nudge

AI learns what each person wants and drafts the SMS. A coordinator checks and sends it.

3 · AND

Money for the garden

Employer matching and grants fund more volunteer days.

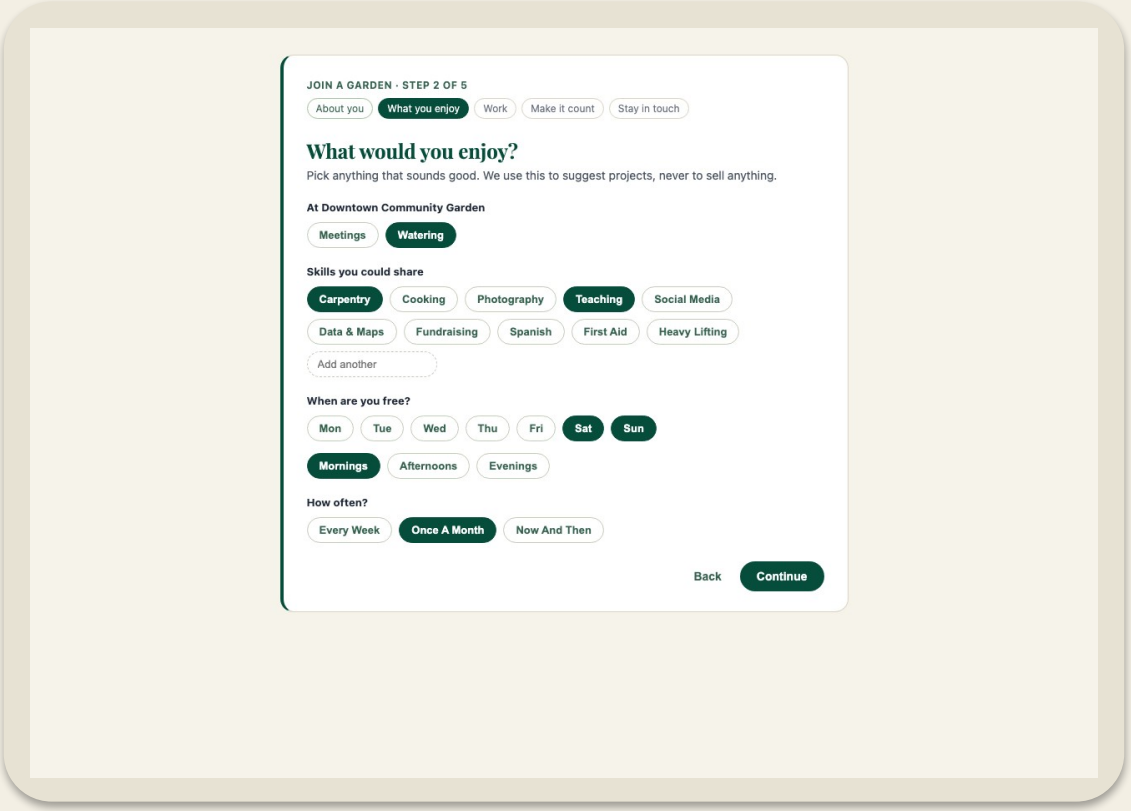
Benefits → return visits → logged hours → funding → more volunteer days.

AI that knows your people

A new five-step sign-up in Garden Steward asks what Roots needs to know:

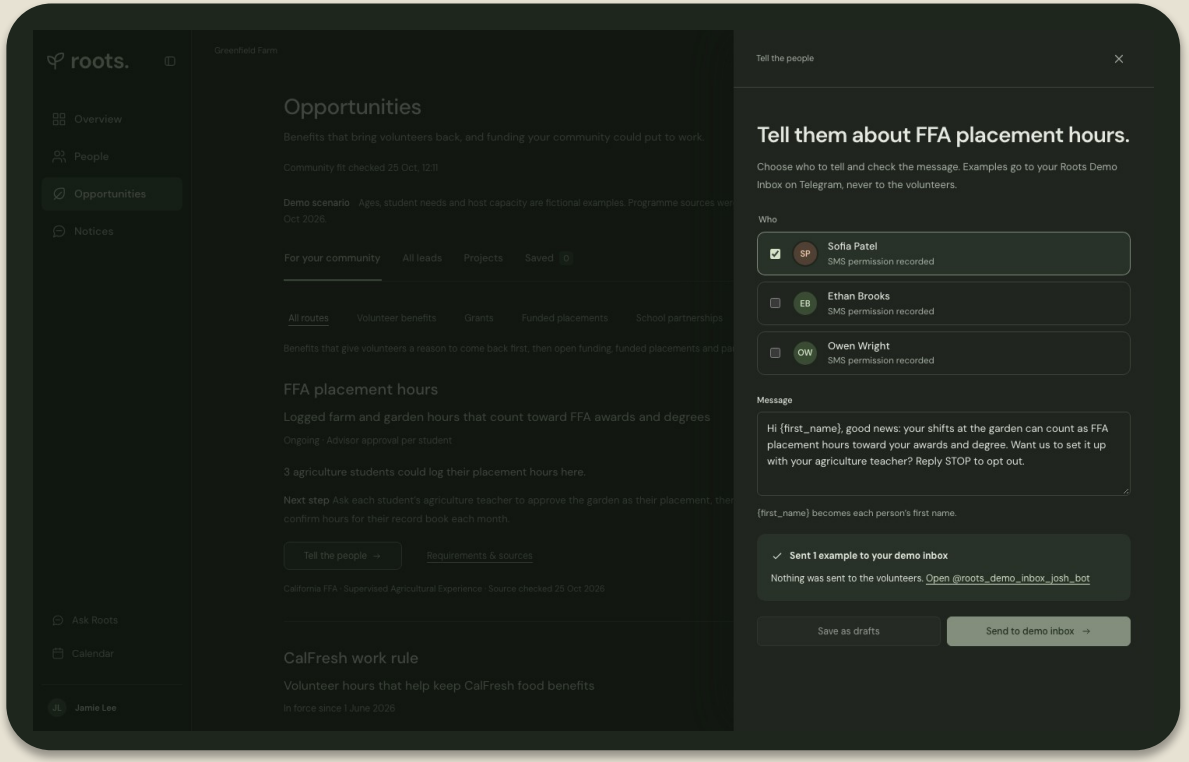
- What they enjoy, and when they are free
- Where they work, plus a LinkedIn link
- Whether their hours could count for school, FFA, college or CalFresh
- Permission to text and email

Every answer lands on their profile, so Roots can match them.



Then a personal SMS, ready to send

1. Roots notices who could benefit today
2. It drafts a message for each person
3. A coordinator edits, approves and sends
4. Text Roots on Telegram: “What needs attention today?”



Nothing goes out until a person says so.

Different reasons for different people

Who	Why coming back pays off for them	In the demo
High-school students	Service hours, and the State Seal of Civic Engagement	8 · 5
FFA students	Garden shifts count as placement hours	3
Community-college students	1 unit of credit for every 60 hours	3
People on CalFresh	Volunteer hours count toward 80 hours a month	4

12 volunteers could gain a benefit by coming back. Roots matches on what people recorded, never on guesses.

Sources: California FFA, CDSS, Peralta colleges, CDE; checked 24–25 Oct 2026. High-school row: 8 with service goals, 5 seal candidates.

Money that funds more volunteer days

$25 an hour

Microsoft employee volunteer matching

3 regulars work there. Where people work is why the sign-up asks.

$2.5k–$10k

CalAgPlate education grant

20 students fit. It closes on 2 November.

Funded fellows

College Corps and Climate Action Corps

Paid placements the garden can host. Next windows open in 2027.

Published programme terms, checked 24–25 Oct 2026. Eligibility still needs confirming for each one.

Simple, affordable and personal

Built into their tools

The sign-up lives in Garden Steward, the Guild’s own open-source platform.

A person approves every message

Roots drafts. A coordinator reviews and sends.

Costs cents

Google Gemini Flash-Lite. A full test run cost a few cents.

True to their data

Matches use what people chose to share. LinkedIn is a link, never scraped.

Demo uses fictional people. SMS delivery is not connected yet; demo messages go to a Telegram demo inbox.

ROOTS

Every hour should count for something.

Let’s pilot it at the Guild’s next monthly work day.

Next: connect SMS · register for employer matching · apply to CalAgPlate by 2 November